

IN CONTEXT

The Congress of Vienna

The economic shock of the Napoleonic Wars (1805–1813) and the repressive measures imposed to unify Europe after the Battle of Waterloo (1815) cast a shadow over the 19th century. From November 1814 to June 1815, Vienna—the seat of the Hapsburg dynasty—hosted a conference of major European powers. Away from the negotiating table, delegates at the Congress of Vienna displayed their wealth at a series of parties and balls. Reports of dancing aristocrats and of court ladies wrapped in silver cloth and covered in diamonds fueled a dance craze among the imperial city's rapidly expanding middle class.



EXTRAVAGANT BALL HELD DURING THE
CONGRESS OF VIENNA, c.1815

Johann Strauss was born in 1825 in Ulrich, near Vienna, several